

STATE OF OKLAHOMA

2nd Session of the 60th Legislature (2026)

COMMITTEE SUBSTITUTE
FOR ENGROSSED

SENATE BILL NO. 1778

By: Pugh of the Senate

and

Hilbert, Staires, and
Hasenbeck of the House

COMMITTEE SUBSTITUTE

An Act relating to the Strong Readers Act; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508A, as amended by Section 3, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508A), which relates to the Strong Readers Act; updating statutory reference; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508B, as amended by Section 4, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508B), which relates to legislative intent; stating legislative intent regarding a multi-tiered system of supports framework and core literacy instruction; requiring schools to integrate other core subjects into reading, writing, and math; defining term; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508C, as last amended by Section 2, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508C), which relates to assessments for reading skills; modifying purpose of screening; directing the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability to evaluate and rank certain number of screening instruments; directing the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability to approve certain instruments; directing the State Board of Education to select one screening instrument; requiring the instrument to meet certain criteria; removing language providing for the approval of three screening instruments; removing language regarding requirements for a program of reading instruction; directing a reading intervention plan to identify intensity of instruction; prohibiting certain services from occurring during math instruction; expanding students who will be provided certain

1 reading intervention plan; adding member to Student
2 Reading Proficiency Teams; removing language
3 regarding certain notification of parents and legal
4 guardians; directing the State Board of Education, in
5 certain consultation, to annually define and set
6 certain benchmarks for screening instrument results;
7 directing the Office of Educational Quality and
8 Accountability to analyze and report certain tiers;
9 prohibiting reading intervention from being provided
10 solely by digital technology; requiring reading
11 intervention to include certain amount of direct
12 instruction; removing certain exemption for students
13 who demonstrate proficiency on certain screening
14 instrument from programs of reading instruction;
15 modifying language regarding intensive intervention
16 services for certain third-grade students; requiring
17 certain first- and second-grade students to be placed
18 in certain transitional classroom or provided certain
19 targeted intervention instruction; allowing certain
20 first- and second-grade students to be voluntarily
21 retained with certain written consent; requiring
22 families of certain first- and second-grade students
23 to be provided certain tutoring or summer reading
24 options; directing the State Department of Education
to approve certain tutoring programs; directing the
Department to make certain assessment available to
school districts beginning in certain school year;
requiring school districts to administer certain
assessment to students in certain grade; providing
for certain prior written notification; allowing
written notice to opt out of certain assessment;
exempting certain students who score at certain level
from certain retention requirements; prohibiting
performance on certain assessment from being counted
against certain grading; directing school districts
to use performance data for certain purpose;
modifying type of intervention services to be
provided to certain students; modifying information
to be included in certain notification for parents
and legal guardians; providing for certain
intervention services for certain incoming third-
grade students; requiring third-grade students to
demonstrate sufficient reading skills beginning in
certain school year; providing methods for
demonstration; requiring retention of certain third-
grade students; prohibiting screening instruments
from being used for promotion purposes; providing

1 good-cause exemptions to retention; providing good-
2 cause exemption request process; requiring written
3 notification of parents and legal guardians of
4 retained students; subjecting certain students to
5 certain screening and testing upon return to a public
6 school; prohibiting certain receiving school from
7 altering certain third-grade retention requirements
8 for a student who transfers; directing retained
9 students to be provided certain interventions
10 beginning in certain school year; requiring school
11 districts to review certain intervention plans;
12 requiring school districts and the State Department
13 of Education to report certain information; updating
14 statutory language; updating statutory references;
15 amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508D, as amended
16 by Section 6, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
17 2025, Section 1210.508D), which relates to
18 appropriated funds designated for the Strong Readers
19 Act; modifying language regarding calculation of
20 certain allocation; providing for calculation of base
21 literacy allocations; providing purpose of base
22 literacy allocation; providing for calculation of
23 supplemental weighted funding; providing purpose of
24 supplemental weighted funding; requiring school
districts to maintain certain documentation;
providing for promulgation of certain rules; allowing
the State Department of Education to require certain
documentation or provide certain assistance under
certain circumstances; directing a portion of certain
funds to be provided as incentives for school
districts demonstrating certain improvement; removing
certain stipend; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section
1210.508E, as amended by Section 7, Chapter 411,
O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508E),
which relates to summer academy programs; allowing a
teacher to recommend certain tutoring; directing
academy programs to incorporate certain reading
intervention services and be taught by certain
individuals; requiring school districts to provide
certain intervention options to certain students;
requiring summer academies to consist of certain
amount of instructional time; prohibiting summer
academies from including certain instruction models;
requiring, rather than allowing, certain intervention
to be expanded to certain grade; requiring school
districts to report certain information to the State
Board of Education; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section

1210.508F, as last amended by Section 3, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508F), which relates to reading competencies for teacher education programs; allowing professional development to include certain components; requiring teacher candidates to study certain negative impacts, identification of certain models, and how to implement certain instruction; requiring certain teacher education programs to be audited for certain compliance; directing noncompliant programs to be placed on certain status and given certain guidance; amending Section 2, Chapter 288, O.S.L. 2023, as amended by Section 9, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508H), which relates to literacy instructional teams; removing pilot program language; directing the State Department of Education to employ literacy coaches who are placed in certain number of regions; providing duties of coaches; providing for priority placement of coaches; requiring coaches to pass certain test; increasing number of coaches; providing additional criteria for coaches; providing for assignment of coaches; exempting a school district that employs certain coaches from using certain literacy coaches if they participate in certain coaching improvement community; modifying criteria for individuals to be given certain preference; prohibiting certain school districts that decline certain assistance from being eligible to receive certain funding; requiring school districts to have certain staff member at each public elementary school; directing the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability, in certain collaboration, to develop certain teacher training academies for certified personnel to provide certain micro-credential; requiring certain teacher training academies to be held prior to the 2026-2027 school year; providing certain stipend for receiving an early literacy micro-credential; providing certain funding amount for certain public and private institutions of higher education; creating the Strong Readers Revolving Fund; specifying sources of fund; providing for expenditures; providing purpose of fund; allowing donors to the fund to designate certain recipient; providing for codification; and declaring an emergency.

1 BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

2 SECTION 1. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508A,
3 as amended by Section 3, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
4 2025, Section 1210.508A), is amended to read as follows:

5 Section 1210.508A. Sections 1210.508A through ~~1210.508H~~
6 1210.508J of this title shall be known and may be cited as the
7 "Strong Readers Act".

8 SECTION 2. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508B,
9 as amended by Section 4, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
10 2025, Section 1210.508B), is amended to read as follows:

11 Section 1210.508B. A. The Legislature finds that it is
12 essential for children in the public schools to read early and well
13 in elementary school. The Legislature further finds that clear and
14 visible goals, assessments to determine the reading level at each
15 elementary school, use of a scientifically based and researched
16 methodology in reading instruction in addition to regular and
17 periodic measurements of elementary school reading improvement, and
18 accountability in each level of the educational system will result
19 in a significant increase in the number of children reading at or
20 above grade level.

21 B. The purpose of the Strong Readers Act is to ensure that
22 progression from one grade to another is determined, in part, upon
23 proficiency in reading, that school district board of education
24 policies facilitate reading instruction and intervention services to

1 address student reading needs, and that each student and his or her
2 parent or legal guardian be informed of that student's reading
3 progress. It is the intent of the Legislature that every student
4 reads at or above grade level by the end of third grade.

5 C. To carry out the purpose of this act, it is the intent of
6 the Legislature that the identification, instruction, and
7 intervention required under the Strong Readers Act be implemented
8 within a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS) framework that
9 emphasizes strong core literacy instruction for all students and
10 provides increasing levels of instructional intensity based on
11 student need and demonstrated response to instruction.

12 D. It is further the intent of the Legislature that strong core
13 literacy instruction consists of explicit, systematic instruction in
14 foundational reading and writing skills including phonological
15 awareness, decoding, encoding, spelling, sentence-level writing,
16 language development, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension,
17 recognizing the reciprocal relationship between reading and writing
18 proficiency.

19 E. Each public school district in this state shall ensure that
20 all students receive a well-rounded education that is focused on
21 building deep foundations in reading, writing, and mathematics. The
22 State Board of Education shall ~~encourage~~ require school districts to
23 integrate the teaching of the other curricular areas in the subject
24 matter standards adopted by the Board with the instruction of

1 reading, writing, and mathematics. All teachers of reading in the
2 public schools in this state in kindergarten through third grade
3 shall ~~incorporate into instruction the five elements of reading~~
4 ~~instruction which are phonological awareness, decoding, fluency,~~
5 ~~vocabulary, and comprehension~~ provide systematic and explicit
6 instruction in the five elements of reading, which are phonological
7 awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, using
8 high quality instructional materials grounded in the science of
9 reading, selected from a list of approved materials maintained by
10 the State Board of Education.

11 ~~D.~~ F. It is the intent of the Legislature that beginning with
12 the 2025-2026 school year, school districts and charter schools in
13 this state shall be prohibited from using the three-cueing system
14 model of teaching students to read. For the purposes of this
15 section, the "three-cueing system" means any model of teaching
16 students to read based on meaning, structure, syntax, and visual
17 cues, which may also be known as meaning, structure, and visual
18 (MSV), balanced literacy, or whole language.

19 SECTION 3. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified
20 in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 1210.508B-1 of Title 70, unless
21 there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

22 A. As used in the Strong Readers Act:

23 1. "Grade-level targets" means the grade-specific benchmark
24 scores established for the screening instrument selected by the

1 State Board of Education in coordination with the Commission for
2 Educational Quality and Accountability;

3 2. "Highly qualified teacher" means a teacher or provider with
4 appropriate training and demonstrated competency in evidence-based
5 reading intervention;

6 3. "Literacy coach" means an educator with demonstrated
7 expertise in evidence-based literacy instruction who provides job-
8 embedded professional learning, modeling, observation, and feedback
9 to teachers to strengthen core instruction and intervention
10 practices within a multi-tiered system of supports framework. The
11 primary responsibility of a literacy coach is to support educators
12 and administrators in improving instructional practices and
13 schoolwide literacy systems. A literacy coach shall not serve in a
14 supervisory or evaluative capacity to maintain a nonevaluative role
15 that fosters professional trust and growth;

16 4. "Multi-tiered system of supports" or "MTSS" means a
17 framework that provides strong core literacy instruction to all
18 students and increasingly intensive levels of instructional support
19 based on student need and demonstrated response to instruction;

20 5. "Reading deficiency" means performance below grade-level
21 targets on a screening or diagnostic assessment indicating that a
22 student is not meeting grade-level expectations in one or more
23 reading skill areas;

1 6. "Reading interventionist" means an educator trained in
2 evidence-based reading instruction who provides supplemental or
3 intensive intervention to students identified with a reading
4 deficiency or significant reading deficiency, aligned to student
5 data and delivered in addition to core instruction;

6 7. "Reading specialist" means an educator who has completed
7 advanced preparation in literacy instruction and assessment and is
8 responsible for designing, delivering, and monitoring targeted and
9 intensive reading intervention services, as well as supporting
10 teachers in addressing reading deficiencies across grade levels. A
11 reading specialist shall have completed a graduate-level specialist
12 degree in reading or literacy and passed the applicable
13 certification examination and shall hold a valid teaching
14 certificate with a reading specialist endorsement;

15 8. "Science of reading" means the body of scientifically based
16 research conducted over several decades and across multiple
17 countries, drawing from multiple disciplines including cognitive
18 psychology, linguistics, neuroscience, and education, that explains
19 how individuals learn to read and write. The science of reading
20 informs instructional practices that are explicit, systematic, and
21 cumulative, and are aligned to the development of phonological
22 awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, comprehension, written
23 expression, and oral language development;

1 9. "Significant reading deficiency" means a reading deficiency
2 that persists despite supplemental intervention and indicates a need
3 for intensive intervention based on student data and response to
4 instruction;

5 10. "Tier 1 - Core Instruction" or "Tier 1" means:

6 a. the evidence-based reading instruction provided to all
7 students as part of the general education program.

8 Tier 1 instruction shall include high-quality,
9 standards-aligned literacy instruction grounded in the
10 science of reading and delivered during the regular
11 instructional day,

12 b. Tier 1 shall include universal screening in
13 kindergarten through third grade and ongoing
14 assessment used to identify students who may require
15 additional instructional support. Tier 1 may also
16 include targeted instructional supports delivered
17 within the core instructional setting to address
18 emerging reading needs, and

19 c. Tier 1 instruction is intended to meet the needs of
20 the majority of students through strong classroom
21 instruction and prevention-focused supports;

22 11. "Tier 2 - Supplemental Intervention" or "Tier 2" means:

23 a. targeted reading intervention provided in addition to
24 Tier 1 core instruction for students identified

1 through screening and progress-monitoring data as
2 requiring additional instructional support to meet
3 grade-level reading expectations. Tier 2 intervention
4 shall:

- 5 (1) provide additional instructional time beyond Tier
6 1 core instruction,
- 7 (2) be delivered in small-group settings, typically
8 consisting of three to five students, using
9 evidence-based instructional practices aligned
10 with the science of reading,
- 11 (3) target specific skill deficits identified through
12 assessment data, and
- 13 (4) include regular progress monitoring to determine
14 the effectiveness of the intervention and guide
15 instructional adjustments, and

- 16 b. a student shall be designated as receiving Tier 2
17 supplemental intervention only when the student is
18 actively participating in scheduled intervention
19 services beyond Tier 1 instruction; and

20 12. "Tier 3 - Intensive Intervention" or "Tier 3" means:

- 21 a. individualized or highly targeted reading intervention
22 provided in addition to Tier 1 core instruction and
23 Tier 2 supplemental intervention for students
24

1 demonstrating a significant reading deficiency. Tier
2 3 intervention shall:

3 (1) provide substantially increased instructional
4 intensity and frequency beyond Tier 2 supports,

5 (2) be delivered in individualized or small group
6 settings, typically consisting of one to three
7 students,

8 (3) be guided by diagnostic assessment to address
9 specific reading skill deficits, and

10 (4) include frequent progress monitoring to evaluate
11 student response to intervention and guide
12 instructional decision-making, and

13 b. a student shall be designated as receiving Tier 3
14 intensive intervention only when the student is
15 actively participating in scheduled intensive
16 intervention services beyond Tier 1 instruction.

17 B. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules
18 establishing implementation guidance for each tier defined in
19 paragraphs 10 through 12 of subsection A of this section including
20 expectations related to instructional time, group size,
21 documentation requirements, and progress-monitoring practices
22 necessary to ensure the effective delivery of intervention services.
23
24

SECTION 4. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508C,
as last amended by Section 2, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S.
Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508C), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508C. A. To identify students who have a reading
deficiency or characteristics of dyslexia that lead to or cause
reading difficulty, each student enrolled in kindergarten and first,
second, and third grade in a public school in this state shall be
screened at the beginning, middle, and end of each school year for
monitoring of progress and for measurement of reading skills
~~including, but not limited to, phonological awareness, decoding,~~
~~fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension. A screening instrument~~
~~approved by the State Board of Education, in consultation with the~~
~~Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and the~~
~~Secretary of Education, shall.~~ The Office of Educational Quality
and Accountability shall evaluate and rank up to three screening
instruments, which shall be approved by the Commission for
Educational Quality and Accountability. The State Board of
Education shall select one screening instrument approved by the
Commission to be utilized for the purposes of this section.

The selected screening instrument shall meet the following
criteria:

1. Can assess for phonological awareness, sound-symbol
recognition, alphabet knowledge, rapid naming skills, decoding and

1 encoding skills, oral reading accuracy and fluency, vocabulary, and
2 comprehension, as developmentally appropriate;

3 2. Can document the validity and reliability of each
4 assessment;

5 3. Can identify students who are at risk for reading and math
6 deficiency and monitor student progress throughout the school year;

7 4. Can be linked to, and can accurately predict, performance on
8 the Oklahoma School Testing Program;

9 5. Is normed beyond elementary grades;

10 6. Can assess students with disabilities and English language
11 learners;

12 7. Is accompanied by a data management system that provides
13 profiles of each student, class, grade level, and school building.

14 The profiles shall identify the instructional point of need and
15 reading achievement level for each student; and

16 8. Is capable of reporting student-level data to the State
17 Department of Education and the Office of Educational Quality and
18 Accountability.

19 B. In determining which screening instrument to approve and
20 utilize, the ~~State Board of Education,~~ the Commission for
21 Educational Quality and Accountability, and the ~~Secretary~~ State
22 Board of Education shall take into consideration at a minimum the
23 following factors:

1 1. The time required to conduct the screening instrument with
2 the intention of minimizing the impact on instructional time;

3 2. The timeliness in reporting screening instrument results to
4 teachers, administrators, and parents and legal guardians of
5 students; ~~and~~

6 3. The integration of the screening instrument into reading and
7 math curriculum.

8 ~~B. Beginning in the 2025-2026 school year, the State Board of~~
9 ~~Education shall approve no fewer than three screening instruments~~
10 ~~for use at the beginning, middle, and end of the school year for~~
11 ~~monitoring of progress and for measurement of reading skills as~~
12 ~~required in subsection A of this section. The screening instruments~~
13 ~~shall meet the following criteria:~~

14 ~~1. Assess for phonological awareness, decoding, fluency,~~
15 ~~vocabulary, and comprehension;~~

16 ~~2. Document the validity and reliability of each assessment;~~

17 ~~3. Can be used for identifying students who are at risk for~~
18 ~~reading deficiency and progress monitoring throughout the school~~
19 ~~year;~~

20 ~~4. Can be used to assess students with disabilities and English~~
21 ~~language learners; and~~

22 ~~5. Accompanied by a data management system that provides~~
23 ~~profiles of each student, class, grade level, and school building.~~

24 ~~The profiles shall identify each student's instructional point of~~

~~need and reading achievement level. The State Board shall also determine other comparable reading assessments for diagnostic purposes to be used for students at risk of reading failure; and~~

4. The ability to report all reading and math screening results to both the State Department of Education and the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability.

C. 1. Exemptions to the screening requirements of this section may be provided to students who have documented evidence that they meet at least one of the following criteria as related to the provision of classroom instruction:

- a. the student participates in the Oklahoma Alternate Assessment Program (OAAP) and is taught using alternate methods,
- b. the student's primary expressive or receptive communication is sign language,
- c. the student's primary form of written or read text is Braille, or
- d. the student's primary expressive or receptive language is not English, the student is identified as an English learner using a state-approved identification assessment, and the student has had less than one (1) school year of instruction in an English-learner program.

1 2. A public school that grants an exemption pursuant to
2 paragraph 1 of this subsection shall provide ongoing evidence of
3 student progression toward English language acquisition with the
4 same frequency as administration of screening assessments. Evidence
5 may include, but not be limited to, student progression toward OAAP
6 reading essential elements, proficiency in sign language and reading
7 comprehension, and proficiency in Braille and reading comprehension.

8 D. 1. Students who are administered a screening instrument
9 pursuant to subsection A of this section and are found not to be
10 meeting grade-level targets shall be provided a ~~program of reading~~
11 ~~instruction designed to enable students to acquire the appropriate~~
12 ~~grade-level reading skills. The program of reading instruction~~
13 ~~shall be based on scientific reading research and align with the~~
14 ~~subject matter standards adopted by the State Board of Education. A~~
15 ~~program of reading instruction shall include:~~

- 16 a. ~~sufficient additional in-school instructional time for~~
17 ~~the acquisition of phonological awareness, decoding,~~
18 ~~fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension,~~
- 19 b. ~~if necessary and if funding is available, tutorial~~
20 ~~instruction after regular school hours, on Saturdays,~~
21 ~~and during summer; however, such instruction may not~~
22 ~~be counted toward the one-hundred-eighty-day or one-~~
23 ~~thousand-eighty-hour school year required in Section~~
24 ~~1-109 of this title,~~

- e. ~~assessments identified for diagnostic purposes and periodic monitoring to measure the acquisition of reading skills including, but not limited to, phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, as identified in the student's program of reading instruction,~~
- d. ~~high-quality instructional materials grounded in scientifically based reading research, and~~
- e. ~~a means of providing every family of a student in prekindergarten, kindergarten, and first, second, and third grade access to free online evidence-based literacy instruction resources to support the student's literacy development at home~~ intervention plan, which shall identify the needed intensity of instruction to remedy the student's specific reading deficiency as quickly as possible.

2. The reading intervention services required by this subsection shall not occur during math instruction.

3. A student enrolled in kindergarten or first, second, or third grade who exhibits a ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency at any time based on the screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section and any fourth-grade student promoted for good cause pursuant to subsection L of this section shall receive an individual reading intervention plan no later than thirty

(30) days after the identification of the ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency. The reading intervention plan shall be provided in addition to ~~core~~ Tier 1 reading instruction that is provided to all students. The reading intervention plan shall:

- a. describe the ~~research-based~~ reading intervention services and the needed intensity of instruction the student will receive to remedy the ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency,
- b. provide explicit and systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, as applicable,
- c. monitor the reading progress of each student's reading skills throughout the school year and adjust instruction according to the student's needs, and
- d. continue until the student is determined to be meeting grade-level targets in reading based on the screening ~~instruments~~ instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section or assessments identified for diagnostic purposes and periodic monitoring ~~pursuant to subparagraph c of paragraph 1 of this subsection~~ by the State Board of Education.

~~3.~~ 4. The reading intervention plan for each student identified with a ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency shall be developed by a Student Reading Proficiency Team and shall include supplemental

1 instructional services and supports. Each team shall be composed
2 of:

- 3 a. the parent or legal guardian of the student,
- 4 b. the teacher assigned to the student who had
5 responsibility for reading instruction in that
6 academic year,
- 7 c. a teacher who is responsible for reading instruction
8 and is assigned to teach in the next grade level of
9 the student, ~~and~~
- 10 d. a certified reading specialist or interventionist,
11 certified personnel with an early literacy micro-
12 credential, or an individual with advanced training or
13 specialization in literacy instruction, ~~if one is~~
14 ~~available~~ and
- 15 e. the principal, vice principal, or designate.

16 ~~4. 5. A school district shall notify the parent or legal~~
17 ~~guardian of any student in kindergarten or first, second, or third~~
18 ~~grade who exhibits a deficiency in reading at any time based on the~~
19 ~~screening instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this~~
20 ~~section. The notification shall occur no later than thirty (30)~~
21 ~~days after the identification of the deficiency in reading~~ The State
22 Board of Education, in consultation with the Office of Educational
23 Quality and Accountability, shall annually define and set benchmarks
24 for screening instrument results that are predictive of future

1 performance on the state summative assessment to assist in
2 identifying intervention tiers within a reading intervention plan.
3 Annually, the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall
4 analyze and report to the State Department of Education the
5 correlation of screening instrument tiers to state summative tiers
6 using predictive modeling and prior year formative and summative
7 testing results.

8 6. Reading intervention shall not be provided solely by digital
9 technology. Reading intervention shall include a majority of direct
10 instruction from a teacher or reading specialist trained in the
11 science of reading.

12 E. 1. Every school district shall adopt and implement a
13 district strong readers plan which has had input from school
14 administrators, teachers, and parents and legal guardians, and if
15 possible a reading specialist, interventionist or certified
16 personnel with an early literacy micro-credential, and which shall
17 be submitted electronically to and approved by the State Board of
18 Education. The plan shall be updated annually if changes have been
19 made to the plan. School districts shall not be required to
20 electronically submit the annual updates to the Board if the last
21 plan submitted to the Board was approved and expenditures for the
22 program include only expenses relating to individual and small group
23 tutoring, purchase of and training in the use of screening and
24 assessment measures, summer school programs, and Saturday school

1 ~~programs. If any expenditure for the program is deleted or changed~~
2 ~~or any other type of expenditure for the program is implemented, the~~
3 ~~school district shall be required to submit the latest annual update~~
4 ~~to the Board for approval.~~ The district strong readers plan shall
5 include a plan for each site which includes an analysis of the data
6 provided by the Oklahoma School Testing Program and other reading
7 assessments utilized as required in this section, and which outlines
8 how each school site will comply with the provisions of the Strong
9 Readers Act.

10 2. The State Board of Education shall adopt rules for the
11 implementation and evaluation of the provisions of the Strong
12 Readers Act. The evaluation shall include, but not be limited to,
13 an analysis of the data required in subsection ~~F~~ S of this section.

14 F. 1. ~~Any first-grade, second-grade, or third-grade student~~
15 ~~who demonstrates proficiency in reading through a grade-level~~
16 ~~appropriate screening instrument approved pursuant to subsection B~~
17 ~~of this section shall not require a program of reading instruction~~
18 ~~or an individual reading intervention plan. After a student has~~
19 ~~demonstrated proficiency through a screening instrument, the~~
20 ~~district shall provide notification to the parent or legal guardian~~
21 ~~of the student that he or she has satisfied the requirements of the~~
22 ~~Strong Readers Act. The district shall continue to monitor the~~
23 ~~student in the next successive grade level to ensure he or she~~
24 ~~maintains proficiency.~~

1 ~~2. Beginning with the 2025-2026 school year, if a third-grade~~
2 ~~student is identified at any point of the academic year as having a~~
3 ~~significant reading deficiency, which shall be defined as not~~
4 ~~meeting grade-level targets on a screening instrument administered~~
5 ~~pursuant to subsection A of this section, the district shall provide~~
6 ~~the student with intensive intervention services for the appropriate~~
7 ~~amount of the instructional day consistent with the individual~~
8 ~~reading intervention plan developed pursuant to paragraph 2 of~~
9 ~~subsection D of this section and as determined by the Student~~
10 ~~Reading Proficiency Team. Intensive intervention services shall~~
11 ~~continue until the student demonstrates proficiency at his or her~~
12 ~~grade level based on a screening instrument administered pursuant to~~
13 ~~subsection A of this section.~~

14 G. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year:

15 a. if a first-grade student has demonstrated the need for
16 reading intervention services and is not meeting
17 grade-level targets by the end of the first grade:

18 (1) the district shall place the student in a stand-
19 alone transitional second-grade classroom or
20 promote the student to second grade while
21 providing targeted Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention
22 instruction, or

23 (2) the first-grade student may be subject to
24 voluntary retention in first grade with the

written consent of the student's parent or legal guardian, and

b. if a second-grade student has demonstrated the need for reading intervention services and is not meeting grade-level targets by the end of the second grade:

(1) the district shall place the student in a stand-alone transitional third-grade classroom or promote the student to third grade while providing targeted Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention instruction, or

(2) the second-grade student may be subject to voluntary retention in second grade with the written consent of the student's parent or legal guardian.

2. If a student is subject to the provisions of paragraph 1 of this subsection, the family of the student shall be provided with the option for the student to attend a summer tutoring program or a summer reading academy. The State Department of Education shall also approve one or two online or workbook-based summer tutoring programs for use by students under this paragraph. School districts shall also provide the parents or legal guardians of the student with a list of summer literacy programs available if a summer academy, as described in Section 1210.508E of this title, is not offered by the school district.

1 3. a. Beginning in the 2027-2028 school year, the State
2 Department of Education shall make available to school
3 districts the statewide third-grade English Language
4 Arts assessment required by Section 1210.508 of this
5 title, and school districts shall administer the
6 assessment to students in second grade. School
7 districts shall provide prior written notification to
8 parents and legal guardians of second-grade students
9 who will be administered the English language arts
10 assessment, and the notification shall include
11 information on how a parent or legal guardian may
12 provide written notice to opt his or her student out
13 of the assessment administration. Second-grade
14 students who score at the proficient level or above on
15 the assessment shall be exempt from the third-grade
16 retention requirements provided in subsection K of
17 this section. A second-grade student's performance on
18 the assessment shall not be counted against him or her
19 in classroom grading.

20 b. School districts shall use student performance data on
21 the assessment administered pursuant to this paragraph
22 to inform intervention decisions.

23 G. Each school district shall annually report in an electronic
24 format to the State Department of Education, the Office of

1 Educational Quality and Accountability, and the Secretary of
2 Education the number of students in kindergarten through third grade
3 per grade level who exhibit grade-level reading proficiency, the
4 number of students per grade level who received ~~intensive~~ Tier 2 or
5 Tier 3 intervention services pursuant to ~~paragraph 2 of~~ subsection ~~F~~
6 D of this section, the number of students per grade level who
7 attended a summer academy as provided for in Section 1210.508E of
8 this title, the number of students per grade level who exhibited
9 improved reading proficiency after completion of ~~intensive~~ reading
10 intervention services, and the number of students per grade level
11 who are still in need of ~~intensive~~ reading intervention services.
12 The State Department of Education shall publicly report the
13 aggregate and district-specific numbers submitted pursuant to this
14 subsection on its website and shall provide electronic copies of the
15 report to the Governor, Secretary of Education, President Pro
16 Tempore of the Senate, Speaker of the House of Representatives, and
17 to the respective chairs of the committees with responsibility for
18 common education policy in each legislative chamber.

19 H. The parent or legal guardian of any student who is found to
20 have a reading deficiency ~~and is not meeting grade-level reading~~
21 ~~targets~~ and has been provided a ~~program of reading instruction~~
22 intervention plan as provided for in paragraph 1 of subsection D of
23 this section shall be notified in writing ~~of~~ no later than thirty
24 (30) days after the identification of the reading deficiency. The

1 notification shall be accompanied by the individual reading
2 intervention plan developed pursuant to paragraph 3 of subsection D
3 of this section. The notification shall include the following:

4 1. That the student has been identified as having a ~~substantial~~
5 ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency;

6 2. A description of the current services that are provided to
7 the student pursuant to subsection D of this section;

8 3. A description of the proposed ~~intensive~~ reading intervention
9 services and supports that will be provided to the student that are
10 designed to remediate the identified area of reading deficiency as
11 provided for in ~~paragraph 2 of subsection F~~ D of this section;

12 4. That the parent or legal guardian shall be informed in
13 writing of the progress of the student toward grade-level reading at
14 least every thirty (30) days and provided with strategies to assist
15 at home;

16 5. That if the child's reading deficiency is not remediated by
17 the end of third grade, the child shall not be promoted to fourth
18 grade unless a good-cause exemption is met;

19 6. That a student who is promoted to the fourth grade for good
20 cause shall receive ~~supplemental intensive~~ Tier 2 or Tier 3
21 intervention services unless he or she is a student who meets the
22 definition of a student with the most significant cognitive
23 disabilities;

1 ~~5. Strategies~~ 7. A description of the specific skill deficits
2 of the child and strategies for parents or legal guardians to use in
3 helping their child succeed in reading proficiency; and

4 ~~6. 8.~~ The grade-level performance scores of the student; and

5 9. That while the statewide English Language Arts assessment is
6 the initial determinate for promotion, students may be provided with
7 an alternative reading assessment option that is recommended by the
8 Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and approved
9 by the State Board of Education to demonstrate sufficient reading
10 skills for promotion to fourth grade.

11 I. No student may be assigned to a grade level based solely on
12 age or other factors that constitute social promotion.

13 J. 1. Any incoming third-grade student identified with a
14 reading deficiency shall be provided Tier 2 or Tier 3 intervention
15 services to remedy his or her specific reading deficiency.
16 Intervention services shall include effective instructional
17 strategies to accelerate student progress and be delivered by a
18 highly qualified teacher.

19 2. Public school districts shall review individual reading
20 intervention plans for all incoming third-grade students identified
21 with a reading deficiency. The review shall address additional
22 supports and services the student will receive. The supports and
23 services shall include reading instruction and reading intervention
24

1 services and supports to correct any identified area of reading
2 deficiency.

3 K. 1. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year, third-grade
4 students shall demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion
5 to fourth grade. Students shall be provided the following options
6 to demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion to fourth
7 grade:

8 a. scoring above the below basic level on the third-grade
9 statewide English Language Arts assessment, or

10 b. earning an acceptable score on an alternative
11 standardized reading assessment as recommended by the
12 Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability
13 and approved by the State Board of Education.

14 2. If the third-grade student cannot demonstrate sufficient
15 reading skills on one of the two options described in paragraph 1 of
16 this subsection and does not qualify for a good-cause exemption, the
17 student shall be retained in the third grade for the next school
18 year. Screening instruments described in this section shall not be
19 used for promotion purposes.

20 L. The school district board of education may only exempt
21 students from mandatory third-grade retention, as provided in
22 subsection K of this section, for good cause. A student who is
23 promoted to fourth grade with a good-cause exemption, except for
24 students who meet the definition of a student with the most

1 significant cognitive disabilities, shall continue to receive
2 reading intervention services that includes specific reading
3 strategies prescribed in the student's individual reading
4 intervention plan until the deficiency is remedied. The school
5 district shall assist schools and teachers with the implementation
6 of reading strategies that research has shown to be successful in
7 improving reading among students with reading difficulties. Good-
8 cause exemptions shall be limited to the following:

9 1. Students with disabilities whose individualized education
10 program (IEP) indicates that participation in the statewide student
11 assessment system is not appropriate, consistent with state law;

12 2. Students identified as English language learners who have
13 had less than two (2) consecutive school years of instruction in an
14 English-learner program;

15 3. Students with disabilities who participate in the statewide
16 English Language Arts assessment and who have an IEP that reflects
17 that the student has received reading intervention for more than two
18 (2) school years but still demonstrates a reading deficiency, or who
19 was previously retained for one (1) year in kindergarten, first,
20 second, or third grade; and

21 4. Students who have received reading intervention services for
22 two (2) or more years but still demonstrate a reading deficiency,
23 and who were previously retained in kindergarten, first, second, or
24

1 third grade for a total of two (2) years. No student shall be
2 retained twice in third grade.

3 M. Requests to exempt students from the mandatory third-grade
4 retention requirement, as provided in subsection K of this section,
5 using one of the good-cause exemptions, as described in subsection L
6 of this section, shall be made consistent with the following:

7 1. Documentation shall be submitted from the student's teacher
8 to the school principal indicating that the promotion of the student
9 is appropriate. Such documentation shall consist only of the good-
10 cause exemption being requested and the existing reading
11 intervention plan or IEP;

12 2. The school principal shall review and discuss the
13 recommendation for exemption with the student's teacher. If the
14 principal determines that the student meets one of the good-cause
15 exemptions based on the discussion and documentation provided, the
16 school principal shall make such recommendation in writing to the
17 school district superintendent. The school district superintendent
18 shall accept or reject the school principal's recommendation in
19 writing; and

20 3. The parents or legal guardians of a third-grade student
21 eligible for a good-cause exemption may choose that the student be
22 retained for one (1) year even if the school district superintendent
23 accepts a recommendation for a good-cause exemption pursuant to this
24 subsection.

1 N. The school district shall provide written notification to
2 the parent or legal guardian of any student who is retained. Such
3 notification shall state that his or her child has not met the
4 reading level required for promotion to the fourth grade, the
5 reasons the child is not eligible for a good-cause exemption, and
6 that his or her child will be retained in third grade. The
7 notification shall include a description of the proposed reading
8 intervention services and the intensity of instruction that will be
9 provided to the child to remedy the identified areas of reading
10 deficiency in the retained year.

11 O. 1. Students that are withdrawn from public school to bypass
12 third-grade retention requirements, as outlined in subsection K of
13 this section, shall be subject to screening upon return to the
14 public school system to determine appropriate grade level upon re-
15 entry.

16 2. If a third-grade student subject to retention as provided
17 for in subsection K of this section transfers to a public school
18 district, a charter school, or a virtual charter school, the
19 requirements to retain the student in third grade shall not be
20 altered by the receiving school.

21 P. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year, students retained
22 under the provisions of subsection K of this section shall be
23 provided Tier 2 or Tier 3 reading interventions to remedy the
24 student's specific reading deficiency. The reading intervention

1 services shall include effective instructional strategies to
2 accelerate student progress. Each school district shall conduct a
3 review of student reading intervention plans for all students
4 retained in third grade. The review shall address additional
5 supports and services needed to remedy the identified areas of
6 reading deficiency and ensure the following are provided to retained
7 students:

8 1. A teacher with appropriate training and demonstrated
9 competency in evidence-based reading intervention. School districts
10 with only one third-grade teacher are exempt from the requirements
11 of this paragraph;

12 2. Tier 2 or Tier 3 reading intervention services and supports
13 to correct the identified areas of reading deficiency;

14 3. One of the following intervention supports:

- 15 a. before-, during-, or after-school supplemental
16 research-based reading intervention delivered by a
17 teacher or tutor with specialized reading training, or
18 b. summer academy programs designed to ensure that
19 participating students successfully complete grade-
20 level competencies in reading to enhance next-grade
21 readiness; and

22 4. A "Read at Home" plan as created by the Office of
23 Educational Quality and Accountability shall be outlined in a
24 parental or legal guardian notification, including participation in

1 parent or legal guardian training workshops or regular parent-guided
2 or legal guardian-guided home reading activities which are aligned
3 to scientifically based reading research.

4 Q. 1. Each school district board of education shall annually
5 publish on the school website and report electronically to the State
6 Department of Education, the Office of Educational Quality and
7 Accountability, and the Secretary of Education by September 1 of
8 each year the following information on the prior school year:

9 a. the policies and procedures adopted by the school
10 district board of education to implement the
11 provisions of this section. The information submitted
12 shall include expenditures related to implementing the
13 provisions of this section, the number of staff
14 implementing the provisions of this section, and
15 average daily classroom time devoted to implementing
16 the provisions of this section,

17 b. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in
18 kindergarten through third grade who ~~did not meet~~
19 ~~grade-level targets~~ demonstrated a reading deficiency
20 based on a screening instrument administered pursuant
21 to subsection A of this section,

22 c. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in
23 kindergarten through third grade who have been
24 enrolled in the district for fewer than two (2) years,

- 1 d. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in
2 kindergarten through third grade who were retained,
- 3 e. by grade, the number and percentage of students in
4 kindergarten through third grade who demonstrated
5 grade-level proficiency based on a screening
6 instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of
7 this section, ~~and~~
- 8 ~~e.~~
- 9 f. by grade, the number and percentage of students in
10 kindergarten through third grade who are on an
11 individualized education program (IEP) in accordance
12 with the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act
13 (IDEA) and who demonstrated grade-level proficiency
14 based on a screening instrument administered pursuant
15 to subsection A of this section or an alternative
16 assessment prescribed by the student's IEP,
- 17 g. the number and percentage of all students in third
18 grade who demonstrated sufficient reading skills for
19 promotion to the next grade on the alternative reading
20 assessment,
- 21 h. the number and percentage of students in third grade
22 who were promoted to fourth grade for good cause and
23 the applicable good-cause exemption specified in
24 subsection L of this section, and

1 i. the performance of fourth-grade students on the
2 statewide English Language Arts assessment who were
3 promoted with a good-cause exemption in the previous
4 school year.

5 2. The State Department of Education shall establish a uniform
6 format for school districts to report the information required in
7 this subsection. The format shall be developed with input from
8 school districts and shall be provided not later than ninety (90)
9 days prior to the annual due date. The Department shall annually
10 compile the information required, along with state-level summary
11 information, and electronically report the information to the
12 public, the Governor, the Secretary of Education, the President Pro
13 Tempore of the Senate, and the Speaker of the House of
14 Representatives and shall post such information on its website.

15 3. If a school district fails to report screening instrument
16 data to the State Department of Education and the Office of
17 Educational Quality and Accountability as required by this
18 subsection, such district shall not be eligible to receive funds
19 pursuant to Section 1210.508D of this title.

20 ~~K.~~ R. The State Department of Education shall provide technical
21 assistance as needed to aid school districts in administering the
22 provisions of the Strong Readers Act.

23 ~~L.~~ S. On or before January 31 of each year, the State
24 Department of Education shall electronically submit to the Governor,

1 the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, the Speaker of the House of
2 Representatives, and members of the committees with responsibility
3 over common education in both houses of the Legislature a Strong
4 Readers Report which shall include, but is not limited to, trend
5 data detailing three (3) years of data, disaggregated by student
6 subgroups to include economically disadvantaged, major racial or
7 ethnic groups, students with disabilities, and English language
8 learners, as appropriate for the following:

9 1. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in
10 kindergarten through third grade determined to be at risk for
11 reading difficulties compared to the total number of students
12 enrolled in each grade;

13 2. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in
14 kindergarten who continue to be at risk for reading difficulties as
15 determined by the year-end administration of the screening
16 instrument required in subsection A of this section;

17 3. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in
18 kindergarten through third grade who have successfully completed
19 their program of reading instruction and are reading on grade level
20 as determined by the results of a screening instrument
21 administered pursuant to subsection A of this section;

22 4. The statewide aggregate and district-specific number and
23 percentage of students that meet or do not meet grade-level targets
24

1 for reading based on a screening ~~instruments~~ instrument administered
2 pursuant to subsection A of this section;

3 5. The statewide aggregate and district-specific number and
4 percentage of students that were retained in third grade;

5 6. The amount of funds received by each district for
6 implementation of the Strong Readers Act;

7 ~~6.~~ 7. An evaluation and narrative interpretation of the report
8 data analyzing the impact of the Strong Readers Act on students'
9 ability to read at grade level;

10 ~~7.~~ 8. The type of reading instruction practices and methods
11 currently being used by school districts in the state;

12 ~~8.~~ 9. Socioeconomic information, access to reading resources
13 outside of school, and screening for and identification of learning
14 disabilities for students not reading at the appropriate grade level
15 in kindergarten and first through third grade;

16 ~~9.~~ 10. By grade level, the types of intensive intervention
17 efforts being conducted by school districts for students who are not
18 on an IEP and who are not reading at the appropriate grade level and
19 for students who are on an IEP and who are not reading at the
20 appropriate grade level; and

21 ~~10.~~ 11. Any recommendations for improvements or amendments to
22 the Strong Readers Act.

1 The State Department of Education may contract with an
2 independent entity for the reporting and analysis requirements of
3 this subsection.

4 ~~M. T.~~ Copies of the results of the screening ~~instruments~~
5 instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section
6 shall be made a part of the permanent record of each student.

7 SECTION 5. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508D,
8 as amended by Section 6, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
9 2025, Section 1210.508D), is amended to read as follows:

10 Section 1210.508D. A. Contingent on the provision of
11 appropriated funds designated for the Strong Readers Act, ~~school~~
12 ~~districts may be allocated monies for each enrolled kindergarten~~
13 ~~student or first-, second-, and third-grade student of the current~~
14 ~~school year who is found to be in need of remediation or intensive~~
15 ~~intervention services in reading. The allocation shall be~~
16 ~~distributed to each school district upon approval of the strong~~
17 ~~readers plan for the school district by the State Board of Education~~
18 ~~and the submittal of a child count report to the State Department of~~
19 ~~Education that details the number of students identified as needing~~
20 ~~remediation or intensive intervention services in reading. To~~
21 ~~determine a per-student allocation amount, the total amount of funds~~
22 ~~available for allocation each year shall be divided by the total~~
23 ~~number of students in the state identified as in need of remediation~~
24 ~~or intensive intervention services in reading as provided for in~~

1 ~~Section 1210.508C of this title. Each school district shall be~~
2 ~~allocated an amount equal to the per student allocation amount~~
3 ~~multiplied by the number of identified students enrolled in the~~
4 ~~school district.~~

5 ~~B. Beginning with the 2022-2023 school year, districts~~
6 ~~receiving more than Two Thousand Five Hundred Dollars (\$2,500.00)~~
7 ~~pursuant to subsection A of this section shall spend no less than~~
8 ~~ten percent (10%) to provide professional development for teachers~~
9 ~~teaching prekindergarten through grade five. The professional~~
10 ~~development shall include training in the science of reading~~
11 ~~including how students learn to read; training in providing explicit~~
12 ~~and systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding,~~
13 ~~fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension; implementing reading~~
14 ~~strategies that research has shown to be successful in improving~~
15 ~~reading among students with reading difficulties; and instructional~~
16 ~~materials required for implementation.~~

17 ~~C. By June 30, 2022, the Department shall approve and publish a~~
18 ~~list of professional development programs that are evidence-based~~
19 ~~and directly address the cognitive science of how students learn to~~
20 ~~read for which districts are permitted to use the funds received~~
21 ~~under this section~~ each school district shall receive a base
22 literacy allocation calculated on a per-student basis for each
23 student enrolled in kindergarten and grades one through three, as
24

1 reported in the October 1 enrollment counts of the current school
2 year.

3 The base literacy allocation shall support the prevention of
4 reading deficiencies and the implementation of strong core literacy
5 instruction within Tier 1 of a multi-tiered system of supports
6 (MTSS) framework, including, but not limited to:

7 1. Evidence-based core literacy instruction and instructional
8 materials aligned with the science of reading;

9 2. Universal screening and diagnostic assessment necessary to
10 identify students at risk for reading deficiencies;

11 3. Progress monitoring and data use to inform instructional
12 decisions;

13 4. Family literacy resources and engagement activities aligned
14 with classroom instruction; and

15 5. Professional development and instructional coaching
16 necessary to implement the district strong readers plan.

17 The State Board of Education shall allocate not less than forty
18 percent (40%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section to
19 support the base literacy allocation described in this subsection.

20 B. 1. In addition to the base literacy allocation provided
21 pursuant to subsection A of this section, school districts shall
22 receive supplemental weighted funding for students identified
23 through screening and progress-monitoring data as requiring
24

1 additional reading intervention services within a multi-tiered
2 system of supports (MTSS) framework.

3 2. Supplemental weighted funding shall support intervention
4 services beyond Tier 1 core instruction and shall be distributed
5 according to the following categories:

6 a. Tier 2 - Supplemental Intervention Weight: Students
7 identified as requiring targeted reading intervention
8 beyond core instruction shall generate supplemental
9 funding to support additional instructional time,
10 reduced group size, and evidence-based intervention,
11 and

12 b. Tier 3 - Intensive Intervention Weight: Students
13 identified as demonstrating a significant reading
14 deficiency requiring intensive, individualized, or
15 highly targeted intervention shall generate
16 supplemental funding reflecting the increased
17 instructional intensity required at this level.

18 3. Supplemental funding received pursuant to this subsection
19 shall be used exclusively for intervention services beyond Tier 1
20 core instruction, including:

21 a. additional instructional time devoted to reading
22 intervention,

23 b. reduced instructional group sizes necessary to deliver
24 intensive instruction,

- c. specialized instructional materials and intervention programs aligned with the science of reading,
- d. compensation for educators delivering intervention services, and
- e. professional development necessary to ensure educators providing intervention services have extensive training in the science of reading.

4. The State Board of Education shall allocate not less than thirty percent (30%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section to support supplemental weighted intervention funding described in this subsection and shall promulgate rules establishing the methodology for calculating weights, documentation requirements, and procedures for verifying intervention participation.

5. Students shall be counted for purposes of supplemental weighted funding pursuant to this subsection only when the school district has documented and electronically reported to the State Department of Education that the student is receiving intervention services consistent with the level of instructional intensity required at the applicable tier.

6. School districts shall maintain documentation demonstrating:

- a. identification of the student through an approved universal screening assessment and supporting diagnostic or progress-monitoring data,

1 b. implementation of an intervention plan specifying the
2 instructional approach, frequency, duration, and group
3 size of intervention services, and

4 c. ongoing progress monitoring used to determine the
5 effectiveness of the intervention and inform
6 instructional adjustments.

7 7. Students shall not generate supplemental weighted funding
8 unless intervention services are provided beyond Tier 1 core
9 instruction. The State Department of Education may review
10 intervention documentation and program implementation to verify
11 eligibility for supplemental weighted funding distributed pursuant
12 to this section.

13 8. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules
14 establishing reasonable expectations for the proportion of students
15 receiving supplemental and intensive intervention services within a
16 multi-tiered system of supports framework.

17 9. When the reported percentage of students receiving Tier 2 or
18 Tier 3 intervention services significantly exceeds expected ranges,
19 the State Department of Education may require additional
20 documentation or provide technical assistance to ensure intervention
21 services are implemented with the instructional intensity required
22 at each tier.

23 C. 1. In order to encourage continuous improvement in student
24 reading outcomes and to support the sustainability of effective

1 intervention services, a portion of funds appropriated pursuant to
2 this section shall be used to provide incentives to school districts
3 demonstrating measurable improvement in student reading performance.

4 2. Incentive funding may include recognition of:

- 5 a. students who demonstrate sufficient progress to exit
6 Tier 3 intensive intervention,
7 b. students who demonstrate sufficient progress to exit
8 Tier 2 supplemental intervention, and
9 c. schools or districts demonstrating measurable
10 reductions in the number or percentage of students
11 requiring supplemental or intensive intervention.

12 3. The State Board of Education shall allocate up to thirty
13 percent (30%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section for
14 literacy improvement incentives and shall promulgate rules
15 establishing criteria for determining eligibility for such
16 incentives.

17 ~~D. If a teacher attends and completes a professional~~
18 ~~development institute in elementary reading approved by the~~
19 ~~Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability during the~~
20 ~~summer or when school is not in session, the teacher may receive a~~
21 ~~stipend equal to the amount of the cost for a substitute teacher,~~
22 ~~based on the amount of funds allocated.~~

SECTION 6. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508E,
as amended by Section 7, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
2025, Section 1210.508E), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508E. A. If a teacher determines that a student
in kindergarten or first through third grade is not reading at grade
level by the end of the second quarter of the school year, the
parent or legal guardian of the student shall be notified of:

1. The reading level of the student;

2. The program of reading instruction for the student as
required pursuant to the Strong Readers Act; and

3. The potential need for the student to participate in a
summer academy or other program designed to assist the student in
attaining grade-level reading skills.

B. A teacher who determines a student in kindergarten or first
through third grade is not meeting grade-level targets for reading
may, after consultation with the parent or legal guardian of the
student, recommend that the student participate in and complete a
transitional instructional setting, before-, during-, or after-
school supplemental tutoring, a summer academy program, or other
program.

C. Summer academy programs shall be designed to ensure that
participating students successfully complete grade-level
competencies in reading to enhance next-grade readiness. A summer
academy reading program shall be a program that incorporates ~~the~~

~~content of a scientifically research-based professional development program administered by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability or a scientifically research-based reading program administered by the State Board of Education~~ reading intervention services and is taught by ~~teachers who have successfully completed professional development in the reading program or who are~~ a highly qualified teacher, a certified as reading specialists specialist, interventionist, or certified personnel with an early literacy micro-credential. The program shall provide explicit, systematic, sequential, and cumulative reading intervention services and supports to correct students' identified areas of reading deficiency.

D. School districts may approve an option for students who are unable to attend a summer academy. The optional program may include, but is not limited to, an approved private provider of instruction, approved computer- or Internet-based instruction, or an approved program of reading instruction monitored by the parent or legal guardian. School districts shall not be required to pay for the optional program but shall clearly communicate to the parent or legal guardian the expectations of the program and any costs that may be involved.

E. ~~Subject to the availability of funds, beginning 1.~~ School districts shall provide at least one of the following Tier 2 or Tier 3 reading intervention options to all third-grade students scoring

1 at the below basic achievement level on the third-grade statewide
2 English Language Arts assessment, as well as students who have
3 completed kindergarten through second grade and are at risk of
4 reading deficiency as determined by a screening instrument
5 administered pursuant to subsection A of Section 1210.508C of this
6 title:

- 7 a. before-, during-, or after-school supplemental
8 research-based reading intervention delivered by a
9 teacher or tutor with specialized reading training, or
- 10 b. summer academy programs designed to ensure that
11 participating students successfully complete grade-
12 level competencies in reading to enhance next-grade
13 readiness.

14 2. Summer reading academies shall include, at a minimum,
15 seventy (70) hours of instructional time in reading and shall not
16 use balanced literacy and whole language models, such as three-
17 cueing as defined in subsection F of Section 1210.508B of this
18 title.

19 F. Beginning one (1) year after implementation of this section,
20 the requirements of subsection ~~B~~ E of this section ~~may~~ shall be
21 expanded to apply to students in fourth grade. Each year
22 thereafter, the requirements ~~may~~ shall be expanded by one grade
23 level until the requirements apply to third-grade students through
24 eighth-grade students. ~~Summer academy programs~~ The reading

1 intervention options outlined in subsection E of this section shall
2 be designed for each grade level. Nothing in this section shall
3 prevent the State Board of Education or a school district board of
4 education from utilizing private, local, or federal funds to
5 implement this section.

6 ~~F.~~ G. The State Board of Education shall adopt rules to
7 implement the provisions of this section ~~which shall include~~
8 ~~requirements for instructional time for summer academy programs,~~
9 ~~teacher qualifications, and evaluation of student achievement as a~~
10 ~~result of summer academy programs or other optional programs and~~
11 shall require school districts to report statewide assessment data
12 aggregated to the classroom level, on the availability of reading
13 intervention options, the number of students participating in each
14 option, and evaluation of student achievement as a result of each
15 provided option.

16 SECTION 7. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508F,
17 as last amended by Section 3, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S.
18 Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508F), is amended to read as follows:

19 Section 1210.508F. A. The Commission for Educational Quality
20 and Accountability shall ensure that the reading competencies for
21 elementary teachers are included in the competencies for special
22 education teachers.

23 B. The Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability in
24 collaboration with the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education

1 shall ensure that all teachers ~~and adjuncts~~ of early childhood
2 education, elementary education, and special education are provided
3 quality training in intervention, instruction, and remediation
4 strategies in the science of reading to provide explicit and
5 systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding, fluency,
6 vocabulary, and comprehension and implement reading strategies that
7 research has shown to be successful in improving reading among
8 students with reading difficulties. Professional development may
9 include effective use of data, progress monitoring, and intervention
10 planning as it fits into a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS)
11 framework. In addition, quality education for prospective teachers
12 shall be provided in research-based instructional strategies for
13 instruction, assessment, and intervention for literacy development
14 for all students including advanced readers, typically developing
15 readers, and struggling readers who are coping with a range of
16 challenges including, but not limited to, English language learners,
17 students at risk for reading deficiencies, and ~~learners~~ students
18 with handicapping conditions and learning disabilities, including
19 dyslexia. Quality training shall include guidance from professional
20 resources such as the Report of the National Reading Panel, Response
21 to Intervention guidelines, and professional organizations such as
22 the Council for Exceptional Children, International Dyslexia
23 Association, International Literacy Association, National Council of
24

1 Teachers of English, and National Association for the Education of
2 Young Children.

3 C. All institutions within The Oklahoma State System of Higher
4 Education that offer elementary, early childhood education, or
5 special education programs approved by the Commission for
6 Educational Quality and Accountability shall incorporate into those
7 programs the requirement that teacher candidates study the five
8 elements of reading instruction which are phonological awareness,
9 decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension and study methods
10 based on the science of reading. Teacher candidates shall study
11 strategies including, but not limited to, instruction that is
12 explicitly taught, sequenced, multimodal (reading, writing,
13 speaking, listening, hands-on, etc.), multidisciplinary, and
14 reflective to adapt for individual learners. Additionally, teacher
15 candidates shall study the negative impacts of balanced literacy and
16 whole language models, including three-cueing practices. They shall
17 further study how to identify balanced literacy and whole language
18 models including three-cueing practices in curriculum, and
19 subsequently, learn how to implement reading instruction using high-
20 quality instructional materials grounded in the science of reading
21 which do not include balanced literacy and whole language models
22 such as three-cueing.

23 D. Each teacher education program approved by the Commission
24 for Educational Quality and Accountability shall be audited by the

1 Commission to ensure teacher candidates are receiving quality
2 training in the science of reading. The Commission shall place the
3 accreditation of any noncompliant teacher education program on
4 probationary status and provide guidance for exiting probationary
5 status.

6 E. Effective July 1, 2025, any person seeking initial
7 certification in a special education, early childhood education, or
8 elementary education program in this state shall be required to
9 successfully complete a comprehensive reading instruction assessment
10 approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and
11 Accountability as a condition for certification. The assessment
12 shall be aligned to scientifically based reading research and
13 evaluate the certification applicant's knowledge and understanding
14 of the five elements of reading instruction which are phonological
15 awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension.

16 ~~E.~~ F. Candidates applying for adjunct positions, an alternative
17 placement teaching certificate, or an emergency teaching certificate
18 in elementary education shall complete instruction in the science of
19 reading as determined by the Commission for Educational Quality and
20 Accountability and the State Board of Education.

21 SECTION 8. AMENDATORY Section 2, Chapter 288, O.S.L.
22 2023, as amended by Section 9, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S.
23 Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508H), is amended to read as follows:
24

1 Section 1210.508H. A. Beginning with the ~~2023-2024~~ 2026-2027
2 school year, the State Department of Education shall establish and
3 maintain a ~~three-year pilot~~ program to employ a literacy
4 ~~instructional team~~ coaches to support school districts in
5 implementation of the requirements of Section 1210.508C of this
6 title. The Department shall provide technical assistance for
7 literacy instruction, dyslexia, and related disorders, and serve as
8 a primary source of information and support for schools,
9 administrators, and teachers in addressing the needs of students
10 struggling with literacy, reading deficiencies, or dyslexia, ~~and~~
11 ~~related disorders~~ or identified with the risk characteristics
12 associated with dyslexia.

13 B. The Department shall employ a literacy ~~instructional team~~
14 ~~with team members~~ coaches who are placed ~~regionally~~ in six major
15 geographic regions across the state. The literacy ~~instructional~~
16 ~~teams~~ coaches shall assist schools, administrators, educators, and
17 general education and special education teachers in recognizing
18 educational needs to improve literacy outcomes for all students
19 including those with reading deficiencies or dyslexia or identified
20 with the risk characteristics associated with dyslexia. Priority
21 shall be given to the lowest performing schools on the end-of-year
22 English Language Arts assessment or the statewide reading screener
23 as approved by the State Department of Education. The role of the
24 literacy ~~instructional team~~ coaches shall also include increasing

1 professional awareness and instructional competencies to meet the
2 educational needs of all students including those with reading
3 deficiencies or dyslexia or identified with risk characteristics
4 associated with dyslexia. The Department shall prioritize supports
5 and interventions including enrollment in reading trainings and
6 professional development for schools which have the highest
7 percentage of students who do not demonstrate sufficient reading
8 skills as established by the State Board of Education.

9 C. Literacy coaches shall provide systems and instructional
10 support to schools to strengthen the implementation of evidence-
11 based literacy instruction and intervention and to build the
12 capacity of educators and school leaders to sustain effective
13 literacy practices. Literacy coaches shall serve in a supportive,
14 nonevaluative capacity and shall not conduct personnel evaluations
15 or impose personnel actions.

16 D. Literacy ~~instructional team members~~ coaches employed by the
17 Department shall be required to pass Oklahoma's Foundations of
18 Reading test and shall have training in:

19 1. The science of how students learn to read including
20 phonological awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary, comprehension,
21 writing, and language;

22 2. Foundation of multisensory, explicit, systematic, and
23 structured reading instruction;

1 3. Identification of and the use of appropriate interventions,
2 accommodations, assistive technology, and teaching techniques for
3 ~~struggling~~ students with dysgraphia, dyslexia, a related reading
4 disorder, or reading deficiency;

5 4. The requirements of the Strong Readers Act;

6 5. Special education laws and procedures; and

7 6. Appropriate interventions, accommodations, and assistive
8 technology supports for students with dyslexia or a related
9 disorder.

10 ~~D.~~ E. The literacy ~~instructional team members~~ coaches employed
11 by the Department shall report to the Program Director for Literacy
12 at the Department and ~~have~~:

13 ~~1.~~ A shall consist of a minimum of five twenty regional
14 literacy ~~leads~~ coaches, at least one who shall be designated by the
15 Department as a dyslexia specialist to provide school districts with
16 support and resources that are necessary to assist students with
17 dyslexia. The Department shall give preference to educators
18 applying for regional literacy ~~lead~~ coaches who:

- 19 1. a. hold a master's degree in education with three (3)
20 years of documented successful experience teaching
21 reading as evidenced by reading assessment scores, or
22 b. hold a bachelor's degree with five (5) years of
23 documented successful experience teaching reading as
24 evidenced by reading assessment scores with a minimum

of three (3) years of literacy experience at the
state, district, or school level;

2. Have a valid certificate to teach issued by the State Board
of Education;

3. Have experience delivering professional development specific
to literacy instruction, mentoring and coaching classroom teachers,
leading others in a collaborative process, and analyzing and using
student performance data for instructional purposes;

~~have~~ 4. Have an endorsement or certification as a certified
structured literacy dyslexia specialist or certified academic
language therapist~~;~~

~~b. are~~
5. Are knowledgeable of multitiered systems of support~~;~~ and

~~c. have~~

6. Have been trained in the identification of and ~~intervention~~
~~for dyslexia and related disorders including best practice~~ the use
of appropriate interventions ~~and treatment models for,~~
accommodations, and teaching techniques for students with
dysgraphia, dyslexia, ~~and~~

~~2. A minimum of ten literacy specialists,~~ a related reading
disorder, or reading deficiency.

F. 1. The State Department of Education shall assign literacy
coaches to school districts that are identified by the Department
based on the number and percentage of students scoring in the below

basic performance level on the statewide third-grade assessment administered pursuant to Section 1210.508C of this title or the statewide reading screener in kindergarten through second grade.

2. If a district already employs instructional coaches, that district shall not be required to utilize Department-assigned literacy coaches so long as the local instructional coaches participate in a Department-led coaching improvement community aligned to the science of reading and national coaching best practices.

G. Literacy coaches assigned to school districts pursuant to the provisions of this section shall:

1. Provide technical support to teachers responsible for reading instruction and reading specialists and interventionists;

2. Assist administrators, educators, and reading specialists and interventionists in implementing evidence-based literacy practices;

3. Design and conduct professional development to meet the needs of teachers and administrators in the area of literacy;

4. Provide clear, practical, timely, and candid written and oral feedback to teachers and administrators based on coaching cycles; and

5. Meet regularly with teachers, reading specialists and interventionists, and administrators to review literacy data and make recommendations for adjustments in instructional practices.

1 H. The Department shall give preference to educators applying
2 ~~for literacy specialist~~ to become a literacy coach who:

3 ~~a.~~ have

4 1. Have training in the science of reading;

5 ~~b.~~ are

6 2. Are knowledgeable of ~~multitiered~~ multi-tiered systems of
7 support; ~~and;~~

8 ~~c.~~ have

9 3. Have been trained in the identification of and ~~intervention~~
10 ~~for dyslexia and related disorders including best practice~~ the use
11 of appropriate interventions ~~and treatment models for,~~
12 accommodations, and teaching techniques for students with
13 dysgraphia, dyslexia, a related reading disorder, or reading
14 deficiency; and

15 4. Have previously retired and were a highly effective
16 elementary school teacher based on student reading scores on the
17 statewide English Language Arts assessment or teacher evaluations.

18 I. If a school district that is prioritized for supports and
19 interventions pursuant to this section declines to accept assistance
20 from a literacy coach, the district shall not be eligible to receive
21 funds pursuant to Section 1210.508D of this title.

22 J. 1. School districts shall have a minimum of one reading
23 specialist, interventionist, or teacher with an early literacy
24 micro-credential for each public elementary school.

1 2. For school districts that do not currently employ or
2 contract with a reading specialist or interventionist, the Office of
3 Educational Quality and Accountability, in collaboration with the
4 State Department of Education, shall work with public or private
5 institutions of higher education within this state to develop
6 teacher training academies for certified personnel to obtain an
7 early literacy micro-credential. The academies shall provide a
8 competency-based professional learning micro-credential after
9 completing an intensive teacher training academy held at Oklahoma-
10 based institutions of higher education.

11 3. The teacher training academies developed pursuant to
12 paragraph 2 of this subsection may include in-person instruction,
13 synchronous online, or hybrid options. The intensive academy shall
14 be focused on MTSS, the science of reading, and standards alignment
15 for early literacy instruction in kindergarten through third grade.
16 Districts shall select at least one member of certified school
17 personnel per school, with priority given to districts without a
18 current full- or part-time reading specialist or interventionist,
19 per year to attend the teacher training academies. Such individuals
20 may be any certified school personnel who will work with students in
21 kindergarten through third grade.

22 4. The Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall
23 set program criteria for the micro-credential course and vet higher
24 education programs seeking to issue the credential to Oklahoma

educators. The Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability shall approve higher education institutions allowed to issue an early literacy micro-credential. Both public and private higher education institutions may apply. The first teacher training academy shall be held prior to the 2026-2027 school year.

5. Instructors for teacher training academies shall possess relevant field experience including demonstrated recent practice in the field.

6. For each member of certified school personnel who will work with grades kindergarten through three who receives an early literacy micro-credential pursuant to the provisions of this subsection, the State Department of Education shall provide:

a. a stipend of Three Thousand Dollars (\$3,000.00) to the certified personnel who receives the early literacy micro-credential, and

b. One Thousand Five Hundred Dollars (\$1,500.00) to the public or private higher education institution approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability to issue the micro-credential.

~~E.~~ K. The State Department of Education shall electronically submit a report to the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, and the Speaker of the House of Representatives by December 31, 2026, that includes an evaluation of the pilot program by school districts, data on whether the program had an impact on increasing

1 the number of students who demonstrate proficiency in reading, and
2 recommendations for changes to the Strong Readers Act.

3 SECTION 9. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified
4 in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 1210.508J of Title 70, unless
5 there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

6 A. There is hereby created in the State Treasury a revolving
7 fund for the State Department of Education to be designated the
8 "Strong Readers Revolving Fund". The fund shall be a continuing
9 fund, not subject to fiscal year limitations, and shall consist of
10 all monies received by the State Department of Education from
11 private businesses, nonprofit organizations, and federally
12 recognized Indian tribes or nations. All monies accruing to the
13 credit of the fund are hereby appropriated and may be budgeted and
14 expended by the State Department of Education for the purpose of
15 improving reading outcomes in accordance with the Strong Readers Act
16 or in accordance with other programs supporting this act.
17 Expenditures from the fund shall be made upon warrants issued by the
18 State Treasurer against claims filed as prescribed by law with the
19 Director of the Office of Management and Enterprise Services for
20 approval and payment.

21 B. Donors to the Strong Readers Revolving Fund shall designate
22 a specific school, school district, or region to receive their
23 donation. The State Department of Education shall distribute monies
24

1 from the Strong Readers Revolving Fund in strict compliance with
2 donor designations required by this subsection.

3 C. Monies in the Strong Readers Revolving Fund may be expended
4 for implementation support services, teacher training, data
5 integration, evaluation, reporting, micro-credential stipends and
6 program fees, and professional learning, to support statewide MTSS
7 implementation goals.

8 SECTION 10. It being immediately necessary for the preservation
9 of the public peace, health or safety, an emergency is hereby
10 declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and
11 be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

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